



SpeechVibe

Total voice control

SpeechVibe allows complete control over one's PC using voice commands.

You first create a voice profile, which doesn't take too long—and you can start using SpeechVibe. SpeechVibe scans the Start Menu, and launching an installed application is straightforward—just say, "Launch (application name)".



There's something called the Mouse Grid, pictured below. It allows even mouse movements to be controlled by voice. This translucent grid takes up the whole screen and highlights point coordinates. You use the name of the coordinate—such as 3-29, 3-30, and so on—to tell SpeechVibe which action you want performed. So, for example, if your Outlook icon is under coordinate 2-23, you say "2-23" and Outlook will be launched. You can click, move, double-click, right-click, and perform drag and drop operations using the mouse grid. It is so precise, you can even create objects in MS Paint, as we've done here. Not that you'd want to paint this way, but it demonstrates the power

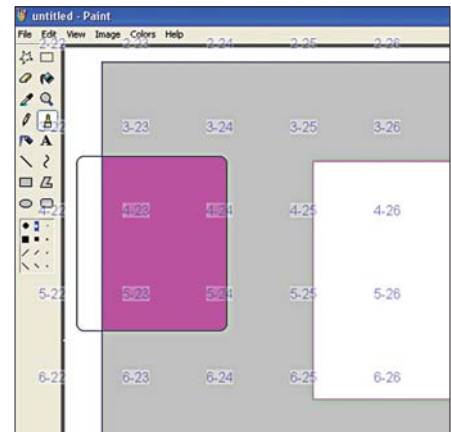
SpeechVibe brings with it.

Browser and mail client support comes inbuilt; when you say "Go to {Web site}", SpeechVibe launches the default browser. A window filled with sorted, numbered, and continuously scrolling favourite

URLs is superimposed. You then open a Web page by saying "Pick {number}".

SpeechVibe also supports speech-to-text by superposing a "dictate environment." This allows you to correct mistakes on-the-fly. An example of this is shown below: a speaker said "Digit", and the word was recognised—and there are several alternatives that you can choose from by saying the appropriate number.

SpeechVibe is not as accurate as expensive voice recognition software, but



the features are innovative. These will take some getting used to, of course. At just Rs 675, you might want to consider this one if you're in the market for speech recognition software. A 30-day trial is on this month's DVD.

Recommended system:

Processor 1700 MHz, Windows XP/Vista, 1GB RAM, Microphone.

Web site: www.speechvibe.com
 Price: \$15.00 (Rs 675)

Xara Xtreme Pro 3.2

An alternative vector-based graphics suite

Xara Xtreme allows designers to create vector-based graphics and illustrations to be used in print and Web-based publishing. It is primarily a vector graphics software, but it incorporates bitmap and Flash editing tools. It is an alternative to Adobe Illustrator CS3 and CorelDRAW X3 for the Windows platform, and has much to prove!

The layout is well-organised with handy tools and easy-to-reach menu bars—most beginners and intermediate users should be comfortable from the start.

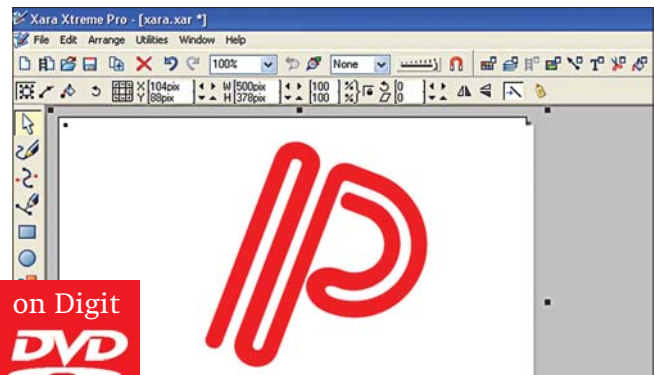
Xara Xtreme allows advanced bitmap editing options. Operations like crop, rotate, auto-enhance, etc. can be applied to bitmap images. Each step in the process of editing is

noted by a picture, so backtracking to earlier versions of the file is possible. The Flash tool is very similar to the bitmap tool; even the interface looks alike. The features available here are pretty basic, though.

You get support for print and pre-press; you can set up multi-page documents and spreads. Xara Xtreme Pro documents can be exported to PDF. There is support for rich text documents—meaning the formatting is maintained in the process.

Linking to an external editor is possible: Xara automatically updates its own document when one saves changes to the file or image in an external application.

Effects are rendered



very fast; memory consumption hovered around the 60 MB mark during our test—pretty good for a graphics suite.

Xara Xtreme Pro turns out to be more than just a vector illustration program. The Pro 3.2 edition packs in some exceptional features for print and Web designers alike. Considering that Adobe Illustrator CS3 retails at \$599 and CorelDRAW X3 at \$399, the price tag of \$249

(Rs 10,000) is decent. Beginners might want to try out Xara Xtreme (not to be confused with Xara Xtreme Pro)—a 30-day trial—from this month's DVD. The feature set is reduced, but the price is unbeatable: \$79 (Rs 3,250).

Recommended system:

Processor 1500 MHz, Windows 2000/XP/Vista, 512MB RAM.

Web site: www.xara.com
 Price: \$249 (Rs 10,000)